

Paramedic Autism Tip Sheet:

Top 6 Tips

What does autism look like?

- Sensory sensitivities (e.g., covering ears)
- Unusual eye contact
- Repetitive motor movements
- Atypical speech or lack of speech
- Delayed responses
- Challenges with social interaction

Remember: Characteristics may present differently across people on the autism spectrum

Tip 1: Before You Arrive

- Turn off sirens, flashing lights
- If possible, contact caregiver for interaction tips and interests of individual

Tip 2: When You Arrive

- Create space
- Get down to their level
- One person talking at a time
- Explicitly say, "I am here to help"
- Avoid touch when possible
- Find a common interest and build rapport



Tip 3: Clear Instructions

- Say exactly what you want the person to do
- Be concise; use short phrases or single words
- Demonstrate what you will do

Tip 4: Give Information

- Explain what will happen step-by-step
- Provide checklist or draw pictures if needed

Tip 5: Create Incentive and Structure

- Use "First-then" to create incentive:
 - Example: "**First**, calm body for two minutes, **Then** play a game on my phone."
- Use a timer for waiting

Tip 6: Remember Related Conditions

- Epilepsy, anxiety
- Hypo-sensitivity to pain and temperature